Los Angeles Times

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ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

PASSENGERS departing the Balboa Island Ferry navigate floodwaters that hit Newport Beach on Tuesday.

El Niño flooding shocks beach towns

Full moon and marine heat wave help lead to record-high tides. Balboa ferry is halted.

BY FEDOR ZARKHIN, HANNAH FRY AND RONG-GONG LIN II

Newport Beach resident Bill Sharp has seen his share of flooding in his six decades on the Balboa Peninsula.

During past El Niño seasons, residents have been known to swap their cars for canoes and paddleboards to get around the peninsula after storms and high tides.

But the record-breaking tides this week took even Sharp by surprise.

Seawater from Newport Harbor surged over seawalls and flowed onto city streets, inundating homes and businesses.

The tide was so high that the Balboa Island Ferry, which has shuttled cars between Balboa Island and the peninsula for more than 100 years, had to temporarily suspend operations.

"It's crazy. We've somehow added 2 feet of water to the normal sea level," Sharp said. "Basically nothing in the city was built to deal with an 8 ½-foot tide."

A full moon on Monday converged with warmer than normal waters to ramp up high tides in Southern California. Ocean temperatures have been affected not only by human-caused cli-

[See **Tides,** A14]

Small businesses turning to risky cash advances

BY AUDREY MCGLINCHY

When sales began falling early this year at Brushstrokes + Beverages, a Long Beach "paint and sip" studio, the owners started looking at options to keep their decade-old business afloat.

Michael Mosselli and his co-owner, Marty Meier, had taken out government-backed small business loans in the past. But this time they needed cash faster — and turned to a fix they hoped would carry them through the downturn. Mosselli said it was a decision made "out of desperation."

Within days last February, the studio owners got $7,200 from a cash advance company based in New York. A couple of weeks later they borrowed more.

The payback agreement required daily withdrawals of a fixed amount of upward of $300 from their business account until the advance and processing fees were paid off, which the company estimated would take almost two months. But they couldn't keep up with the daily payments, and amassed significant penalties. Eventually, they were forced to shutter their business owing more than $34,000 on the borrowed $11,850.

Mosselli and Meier had agreed to what is called a merchant cash advance, commonly called MCAs, and their circumstances offer a cautionary — and in their case, crushing — example of potential pitfalls of this financial tool.

The product is a largely unregulated sector of the financial industry, but one that more small-business owners are turning to as it has become harder to get bank-financed business loans and as tariffs, ICE raids and rising gas prices cut into their revenue. It promises quick cash — but at a high cost.

In 2014, merchant cash advances nationwide totaled about $8.6 billion, according to one federal agency. By 2019, it was estimated

[See **Merchants,** A11]

Feds accuse rehabs of fraud

Facilities allegedly drugged, held patients against will

BY RICHARD WINTON

Nathan and David Young presented their drug and sober care facilities as an attractive option for those in need.

Come to Southern California and we can help you with your addiction, they'd say. And your insurance company will cover the bills.

But now, the father-and-son team are accused by federal prosecutors of using their facilities to commit a shocking fraud.

They are accused in federal criminal complaints of drugging patients, preventing them from accessing their belongings and holding them against their will.

The Youngs are accused of directing "body brokers" across the country to target vulnerable populations, including those who were unhoused, in poverty and attending substance abuse support groups. The pair then had the people sent to their facilities, one of which was Rodeo Recovery in Beverly Hills, according to criminal complaints from the Department of Justice.

The charges were a central part of a wider healthcare fraud crackdown by the Trump administration that netted more than a dozen arrests in multiple states.

They also bring renewed attention to Southern California's reputation as a so-called rehab riviera, where scores of facilities dot the landscape at varying price tags. Investigations are underway after Cindy Crawford's son, Presley Gerber, was found dead last month at a luxury sober living home in Santa Monica.

The Youngs and the other defendants could not be reached for comment. They have not yet entered pleas in response to the charges. Authorities took eight people into custody Thursday and charged 15 defendants, including six medical professionals.

Their lawyers allege the Youngs were held in federal

[See **Rehabs,** A7]

Amid attacks, Saudis say life goes on

BY NABIH BULOS

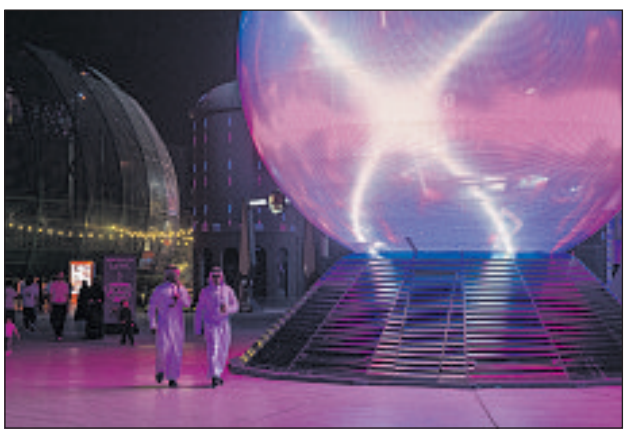
RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — The lineup was announced months ago, with top-flight stars in tennis, DJing, comedy and more set to descend on the Saudi capital for a 10-week run of events known as Riyadh Season.

But after successive missile strikes hit Riyadh's airport this month, killing more than a dozen people, shuttering parts of the country's airspace and setting off a flurry of cancellations, many wondered if audiences would show up, or if there would be anything to show up for at all.

The answer to both questions came this past weekend, when crowds gathered for Riyadh Season's opener at Boulevard City, a car-free district in the capital that's part open-air mall, part amusement park and part entertainment venue.

By the time sunset had turned to dusk, families were milling about a replica of Times Square. Patrons assembled for a sold-out comedy play at one of two theaters, while others went to a

[See **Riyadh,** A4]



MAXIME SELTENRIJCH For The Times

MEN stroll in Boulevard City in the Saudi capital of Riyadh, which still attracts big crowds for its events.

No clear winner emerges in Israel
Exit polls indicate that voters delivered a sharp rebuke to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

FBI raid is tied to Swalwell inquiry
Agents search the Beverly Hills mansion of another onetime candidate for governor. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Ex-Times MLB writer dies at 89
Ross Newhan covered baseball for more than 37 years and was later honored by sport's Hall of Fame. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Sunny intervals.
L.A. Basin: 76/60. **B6**

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Bass overcomes Raman's lead, tying her in poll

Pratt voters give the mayor a boost. The challenger's ll-point advantage disappears.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

The race for mayor of Los Angeles is a dead heat as the campaign draws to a close, with a new poll showing incumbent Karen Bass erasing the double-digit lead previously held by Councilmember Nithya Raman.

Raman and Bass now each have 40% of likely L.A. voters in their camps, with 19% still undecided ahead of the Nov. 3 election, according to the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies poll, co-sponsored by The Times.

The neck-and-neck contest is a big change from September, when Raman jumped out to an 11-percentage-point lead with support from 39% of likely voters, compared with Bass at 28%.

It follows weeks of relentless attacks on Raman by Bass, who some analysts had predicted would need to campaign more aggressively to close the gap with her challenger.

"It's certainly a breath of fresh air for Bass to see the race close. She'll probably feel the campaign is having the effect she wants it to have, which is to put more focus on Raman and put Raman on the defensive," said Mark DiCamillo, the director of the Berkeley IGS Poll.

The survey released Wednesday was conducted online in English and Spanish with a sample of 2,197 likely city voters between Oct. 19 and Sunday. It has a margin of error of about 3 percentage points.

The leveling off of the race, along with the sharp decline in undecided voters, was spurred largely by conservative voters who chose Republican Spencer Pratt in the primary deciding to vote for the mayor in the runoff, DiCamillo said.

In the September Berkeley IGS/Times poll, 22% of Pratt voters said they

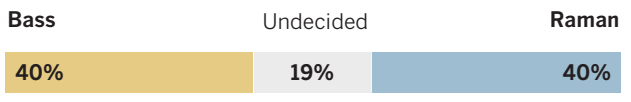
[See **Mayor,** A14]

Roy widens lead in city attorney race

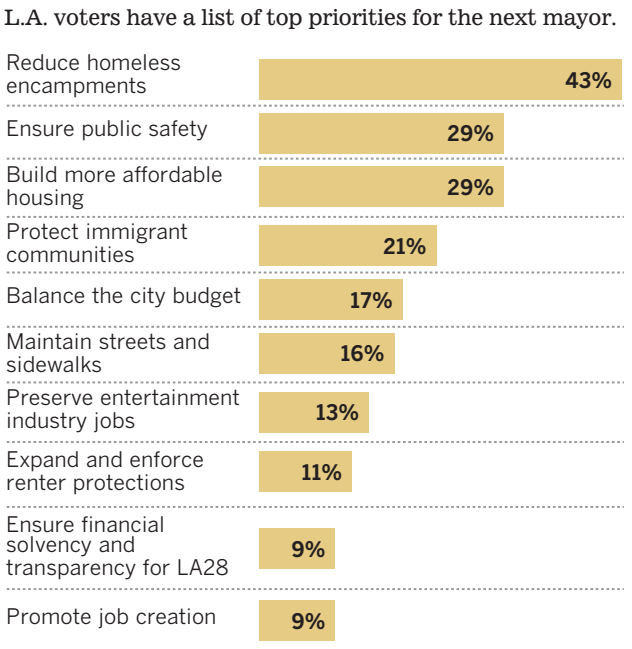
The state official is 17 points ahead of Deputy D.A. John McKinney in latest poll. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Focus on the undecideds

Karen Bass and Nithya Raman are tied in the race for mayor among likely voters with a stated preference.



L.A. voters have a list of top priorities for the next mayor.



Respondents could select no more than two issues.

Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies survey of 2,197 likely voters in L.A. was conducted online Oct. 19 - 25. Responses have a sampling error of about +/- 3 percentage points at the 95% confidence level.

LORENA IÑIGUEZ ELEBEE Los Angeles Times

Slayings fall, race disparity remains

L.A. homicides at levels not seen since 1960s. Black victims are overrepresented.

BY LIBOR JANY

Homicides in Los Angeles still are falling, plunging to levels not seen since the 1960s and continuing a dramatic turnaround from the COVID-19 pandemic crime surge.

But despite the low overall numbers, an old pattern persists: Black Angelenos are far more likely to be killed than those of other races.

So far this year, 35% of the city's homicide victims were Black, even though Black people make up just 8% of the population — roughly the same percentage that they represented 20 years ago. Black victims accounted for 57 of the 162 recorded homicides through mid-September, the most recent period for which reliable data are available. That is down from 75 at this point last year, when there were 192 slayings.

Most experts agree the cause of the decline in homicides may not be known for years, and even then there likely will not be one simple explanation, with disparities in access to healthcare, jobs and adequate housing thought to be among the factors that affect crime rates in communities of color.

Homicides are down in most big cities nationwide. In L.A., police divisions that have long struggled with homicide rates — such as Southeast, 77th Street and Newton — again lead the city. In the 77th patrol area, which covers South L.A. around Florence Boulevard, 12 of the 20 people killed there through mid-September were Black, a Times analysis found. Roughly a third of the area's residents are Black.

The latest data show homicides of Latinos fell slightly and remained slightly lower than their population count. Through mid-September, there were 72 Latino victims killed in L.A., compared with 82 over the same period last year.

[See **Homicides,** A8]